

Political stability, the economy weathering a global crisis, corporate performance, Test cricket triumphs, slumdog millionaires; 2009 didn't turn out so bad after all

| By Dilip Bobb |

Every year produces a defining image, a trademark of the times. Last year, it was the funereal shroud over the dome of the Taj Mahal hotel in Mumbai. This year, it was probably Sachin Tendulkar raising his face heavenwards as he completed a record-breaking 30,000 runs in Test cricket and an even more incredible 20 years in competitive sport. One was a legend devalued by manipulated minds while the other asks us to celebrate greatness and renewal in equal measure. After 2008, a year spent on the edge, wary of what was behind us and of what lay ahead, the collective spirit of revival was a welcome springboard for a new decade.

It's most potent demonstration lay in the anniversary of 26/11, the bright-lit candles inspiring belief that a year without terror was a fitting enough tribute to those who were victims of its most virulent exposition. In sombre ceremonies, we saluted their memories while also celebrating another renewal: the reopening of three landmark restaurants at the Taj Mahal hotel in Mumbai to coincide with the anniversary, the renewal of an equally sombre pledge. Ratan Tata, chairman of the hotel group, declared that: "We made a commitment to rebuild this building brick by brick and stone by stone.... We have risen again, stronger with greater spirit," and that was reflected in the response: every table in all three restaurants had been booked weeks in advance. On one level, it reflected defiance and the indestructible human spirit but at another, more subliminal, was the resilience of the Indian economy. Mumbai had been targeted to destabilise India's financial and corporate capital.

Despite the sustained global gloom, India, along with China, crouching tiger, fire-breathing dragon, bucked the downturn, even registering impressive GDP growth. With

an economist as prime minister and veteran fire-fighter Pranab Mukherjee occupying the hot seat in North Block, the UPA Government's economic Viagra in the stimulus packages seemed to have jump-started key sectors of the economy after the initial slowdown. Indeed, the real back-story of 2009 was the Indian economy as prime-time global story. In November, an international survey showed that India Inc was set to be the world's hottest hiring destination in 2010, with more employers saying they plan to hire a larger number of people than anywhere else in the world. That one of the leading sectors was IT was also an acknowledgement that the explosive Satyam scam at the fourth largest IT company in India had dissipated surprisingly rapidly, thanks to the deft handling of the crisis by the Government.

Not every crisis was so admirably managed but the grey cells and gravitas of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and the political adroitness of Congress President Sonia Gandhi inspired the UPA, minus its leftist luggage, to slip back into the saddle for a second term. Politically, there was only one blockbuster of the year, scripted by mother and son, Sonia and Rahul, showing signs of what a formidable combination they could be. The resurgence of the Congress from being pretty much of a spent force at the start of the decade was entirely due to their combined appeal and electoral strategy in states where it had been moribund for too long. Rahul's discovery of Bharat and his obvious connect with the youth made him the most watched personality of 2009. Another Gandhi awaits his tryst with destiny, unlike cousin Varun whose political debut was a sad and sordid affair, embarrassing the BJP and its leadership with its vicious, and videoed bigotry.

That in no small measure contributed to the slide in the political fortunes of The Alternative with its image of

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